

Bone types

The shape and size of a bone depend on the functions it performs. Bones are divided into five different types, based on their shape—long, short, irregular, flat, or sesamoid.

Long bones

These bones are so named because they are longer than they are wide.

This group includes most arm and leg bones, such as the body's longest bone, the femur, as well as the much smaller phalanges—the toe and finger bones. Long bones support the body and allow it to move freely.

Femur

Short bones

Shaped roughly like cubes, short bones are found in the wrists and ankles. They do not allow much movement, but do help to support the hands and feet.

Wrist bones

Temporal bone

